Caregiver Burnout & Respite Planner

START HERE

A practical planner for family caregivers: notice strain early, hand off tasks, and book real breaks.

HOW TO USE THIS PLANNER

1. Week 1: fill in the Weekly Check-In every evening (2 minutes). It shows you patterns you might not notice day to day.
2. Fill in Where My Time Goes once. Mark every task someone else could do, even partly.
3. Turn those tasks into the Ask-for-Help Menu and send it to the people on your Support Network Map.
4. Use the Respite Options page to research at least two kinds of break, then put them on the Break Calendar.
5. Keep the Caregiver Back-Up Plan on the fridge or in your wallet so someone can step in if you get sick.
6. At the end of each month, use Monthly Reset to decide what to keep, drop or hand over.

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MY CAREGIVING AT A GLANCE

I care for: _____ Since: _____

Main care tasks: _____ Hours per week (approx.): _____

My best support person: _____ My next planned break: _____

This planner is an organising tool, not medical or psychological advice. If you feel overwhelmed, hopeless or unwell, talk to your doctor or a local caregiver support service.

Weekly Caregiver Check-In

WEEK OF _____

Two minutes each evening. Patterns matter more than any single day.

Day	Care hours	Sleep hours	Energy 1–5	Stress 1–5	Real break? (Y/N)	One thing that helped today
Mon						
Tue						
Wed						
Thu						
Fri						
Sat						
Sun						

Total care hours: _____ **Average sleep:** _____

Days with a real break: _____ **Hardest moment:** _____

THIS WEEK I NOTICED tick any that apply

- ☐ Snapping at people more than usual
- ☐ Skipping my own meals or appointments
- ☐ Trouble falling or staying asleep
- ☐ Cancelling plans with friends
- ☐ Feeling I'm the only one who can do it
- ☐ Headaches, tension or getting sick more
- ☐ Dreading the next day
- ☐ Forgetting things I usually remember

One change I will make next week:

_____

_____

_____

Early Warning Signs & My Plan

Write down what strain looks like for YOU, and decide in advance what you'll do about it.

Level	My signs (what I notice in myself)	What I will do
Green: coping		
Yellow: stretched		
Orange: running on empty		
Red: can't keep going like this		

IDEAS FOR THE 'WHAT I WILL DO' COLUMN

- ☐ Ask one person from my support map for a specific task
- ☐ Book a respite break within 2 weeks
- ☐ Say no to one non-essential commitment
- ☐ Make an appointment with my own doctor
- ☐ Call a caregiver support line or group
- ☐ Hold a family meeting about sharing care
- ☐ Go to bed 30 minutes earlier for a week
- ☐ Let a lower-priority task go undone

Person I'll tell when I hit orange: _____ **Phone:** _____

Where My Time Goes

List every regular care task for one week. Mark what someone else could do, even partly.

Care task	How often	Minutes each	Hours / week	Could someone else help? Y / Partly / N	Who?

Total hours per week: _____ Hours others could take: _____

Ask-for-Help Menu

People say 'let me know if you need anything'. Give them a menu. Specific asks get a yes far more often.

Task (be specific: what, when, how long)	Who could do it	Asked on	Answer	Done
Pick up prescriptions on Fridays				
Sit with Mom Tuesday 2–5 pm so I can go out				
Drive to the clinic appointment on the 14th				
Cook or drop off one dinner a week				
Weekly grocery order and put-away				
Call the insurance company about the claim				
Mow the lawn / yard work twice a month				
Phone call with Dad on Sunday evenings				

SAMPLE MESSAGE

"Thanks for offering to help. Here are a few things that would really make a difference. Could you take one? For example, picking up Mom's prescriptions on Fridays, or sitting with her on a Tuesday afternoon for 3 hours."

Support Network Map

Everyone who could help, even in small ways. Fill in names, then contact details below.

Family

Friends

Neighbours

Faith / community groups

Paid help & services

Groups & helplines

Name	Relationship	Phone / email	Good at / available for

Respite Options Planner

Research at least two kinds of break. Costs and availability vary by area, so call and ask.

Type of break	Provider / person	Cost	Hours / days	Contact	Notes
Family or friend swap					
In-home respite visit					
Adult day program					
Short-term residential stay					
Volunteer companion					
Paid sitter / companion					

QUESTIONS TO ASK A RESPITE PROVIDER

- [ ] What does a typical visit or day include?
- [ ] What is the cost and what is included?
- [ ] Can you handle medication, mobility or memory needs?
- [ ] How much notice do you need to book?
- [ ] Who exactly will come, and are they trained?
- [ ] What happens in an emergency?
- [ ] Is there a minimum number of hours?
- [ ] Is any funding or insurance help available?

Break Calendar

MONTH: _____

Book breaks like appointments. Note who covers care while you are away.

Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun

Breaks booked this month: _____ Covered by: _____

Longest break: _____ Next month's goal: _____

Boundaries & Ready-Made Scripts

Decide your limits on a calm day, so you don't have to on a hard one.

I can keep doing

I can't keep doing / need help with

SCRIPTS YOU CAN ADAPT

Situation	You could say
Saying no	"I can't take that on right now. What I can do is ___."
Asking a sibling	"I need you to take ___ every ___. Can you start this week?"
Unwanted advice	"Thanks, I'll think about it. Right now what would help most is ___."
Protecting a break	"Saturday morning is my time off. ___ is covering, please call them."
Talking to your parent	"I want to keep helping you for a long time, so I'm getting some support."
Your own words	

One boundary I will hold this month:

My Own Health Appointments

ME

Caregivers often skip their own care. Track it here like you track theirs.

Check-up / appointment	Last done	Due	Booked for	Who covers care	Done
GP / family doctor check-up					
Dentist					
Eye test					
Screenings my doctor recommends					
Vaccinations					

MY OWN MEDICATIONS & REFILLS

Medication	Dose / when	Refill due	Pharmacy

Questions for my doctor:

Recharge List & One Thing for Me

Small breaks count. Fill the list now, then pick from it when you get a gap.

5 minutes

15 minutes

1 hour

Half a day or more

ONE THING FOR ME EACH WEEK

Week	What I'll do	When	Did it?
Week 1			
Week 2			
Week 3			
Week 4			
Week 5			

Caregiver Back-Up Plan

If I'm sick, delayed or in hospital, this is what someone needs to know. Keep a copy on the fridge.

I care for: _____ Their address: _____

Their phone: _____ Key door / key safe info: _____

WHO STEPS IN

Order	Name	Relationship	Phone	Can cover
1st				
2nd				
3rd				

MUST-KNOW DAILY CARE

Time	What needs to happen	Where to find things

Medication list kept at: _____ Doctor / clinic: _____

Pharmacy: _____ Paid carer / agency: _____

Allergies & important health info: _____ Pets / other dependants: _____

Other things a stand-in must know:

_____

_____

_____

_____

Monthly Reset

MONTH: _____

Look back at your check-ins and decide what to change next month.

Average care hours / week: _____ Breaks taken: _____

Days in orange or red: _____ Tasks handed off: _____

What worked

What was hardest

Keep doing

Stop / drop

Hand over to someone else

Next month's break plan